

Utilitarianism in Normative Ethics

1 Historical evolution and the central thesis

Utilitarianism originated as an attempt to provide an objective and secular account of morality rooted in human welfare. **Consequentialism**—the view that the moral value of an action is determined solely by its consequences—is the foundation of utilitarian thought[1]. Jeremy Bentham’s early formulation of the *principle of utility* asked us to approve or disapprove of actions according to their tendency to increase or diminish the happiness of those affected[1]. Bentham sought to turn morality into a kind of social calculus, proposing to weigh pleasures and pains by intensity, duration, certainty, proximity, fruitfulness and extent. He emphasised **impartiality**: each person’s happiness counts the same, and there is no reason to favour oneself or one’s friends over strangers[1].

John Stuart Mill broadened Bentham’s hedonism. While he agreed that happiness—understood as pleasure and the absence of pain—is the only thing desirable as an end, he argued that pleasures differ in quality. Higher pleasures engage our rational and moral faculties; lower pleasures are bodily and transient. Mill famously insisted that “it is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied; better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied”[2]. Critics argued that his distinction between higher and lower pleasures lacked an evaluative basis[3], yet Mill claimed empirical support: people acquainted with both kinds of enjoyment consistently prefer the higher[4]. Mill also emphasised the **social** dimension of morality. In his fifth chapter of *Utilitarianism*, he describes morality as a system of social rules justified by their tendency to promote general welfare; individuals are morally obliged to obey rules that are part of the justified moral code[5]. Only when rules conflict or fail does one appeal directly to the principle of utility[6].

Henry Sidgwick’s *Methods of Ethics* (1874) developed utilitarianism into a more self-conscious ethical methodology. Sidgwick argued that reflective equilibrium between common-sense morality and the utilitarian principle can resolve moral conflicts. He also introduced the claim—reminiscent of Kant—that rational agents cannot consistently will their own happiness as the sole ultimate end; impartial benevolence provides a more rational ultimate principle.

Early twentieth-century philosophers diversified utilitarianism. G.E. Moore rejected hedonism in favour of **ideal utilitarianism**, according to which goods such as knowledge, aesthetic appreciation and friendship are intrinsically valuable. R.M. Hare's **two-level utilitarianism** distinguished between an **intuitive level** of moral thinking—comprising simple moral rules learned by upbringing—and a **critical level** where one weighs everyone's preferences impartially[7]. Hare stressed that at the critical level, the identity of the agent is irrelevant; one must imagine being any of the persons affected[8]. Contemporary utilitarians such as Peter Singer and Jeff Sebo have expanded the **moral circle** by insisting that all sentient beings—humans and non-human animals—deserve equal moral consideration[9].

1.1 Structural elements and variants

Modern scholarship identifies four structural commitments common to utilitarian theories: **consequentialism**, **welfarism**, **impartiality** and **aggregationism**[10]. **Consequentialism** holds that only the consequences of actions determine their moral worth. **Welfarism** claims that well-being (variously understood) is the only thing of intrinsic moral value. **Impartiality** demands equal consideration of each person's or sentient being's interests. **Aggregationism** sums or otherwise aggregates individual well-being to evaluate states of affairs. These elements support a family of utilitarian theories:

- **Hedonistic, preference and ideal utilitarianism.** Classical utilitarianism equates welfare with pleasure and the absence of pain. Preference utilitarianism instead directs us to satisfy informed preferences[11], thereby respecting individuals' desires for autonomy and authenticity. Ideal (or objective list) utilitarianism recognises goods such as friendship, knowledge and virtue as intrinsically valuable[12], thus answering objections that happiness alone cannot capture all that matters.
- **Act vs rule utilitarianism.** **Act utilitarianism** evaluates each individual act by its expected consequences. **Rule utilitarianism** evaluates general rules by their consequences and instructs agents to follow the rule whose adoption would maximise welfare. Rule utilitarianism aims to protect rights by forbidding rules such as “imprison an innocent scapegoat” or “harvest organs from the healthy.”
- **Expectational vs objective utilitarianism.** Because we often act under uncertainty, **expectational utilitarianism** instructs agents to choose the action with the highest

expected value[15]. **Objective utilitarianism** judges actions by the actual outcomes they produce. The distinction is illustrated by a risky medical treatment: expectational utilitarianism condemns giving a treatment that has a high probability of causing death even if, in rare instances, it saves the patient[16].

- **Single-level vs multi-level utilitarianism.** **Single-level** utilitarianism uses the utilitarian principle directly as a decision procedure. **Multi-level utilitarianism** retains utilitarianism as the ultimate criterion but advises following moral heuristics such as “do not lie, keep promises, respect autonomy” for everyday decisions[17]. At the **critical** level, one reassesses the heuristics and occasionally overrides them. Hare’s two-level theory provides a similar distinction[7].
- **Negative utilitarianism and prioritarianism.** **Negative utilitarianism** gives extra weight to preventing suffering rather than promoting happiness. More moderate versions propose **prioritarianism**, which weights benefits to the worse-off more heavily to address distributional fairness and avoid the so-called **utility monster** (a being who gains so much utility that sacrificing everyone else appears justified)[18].
- **Population ethics variants.** When decisions affect how many people will exist, utilitarians must adopt a stance on population ethics. The **total view** ranks outcomes by the sum total of well-being[19]; this leads to Derek Parfit’s **repugnant conclusion**: for any world with many very happy people, there is a better world containing vastly more people whose lives are barely worth living[19]. The **average view** ranks by average well-being, but it can lead to “sadistic” conclusions, e.g., that adding very unhappy people to a population improves it if it increases the average by diluting existing misery[20]. **Variable value** and **critical-level** theories attempt to avoid these extremes by giving diminishing value to additional lives beyond a threshold[21].

These variants reveal that utilitarianism is not a single monolithic doctrine but a family of theories sharing core commitments and diverging on the nature of well-being, the scope of aggregation, the decision procedure and the treatment of population ethics.

2 Arguments in favour of utilitarianism

Why adopt a utilitarian moral theory? Philosophers have offered several justificatory arguments. Though no argument is conclusive—moral theories cannot be proven mathematically—utilitarianism is supported by theoretical virtues, fairness considerations and practical success.

2.1 Simplicity, coherence and theoretical virtues

Utilitarianism is a **simple and unified** theory. A single moral principle—promote well-being—is both easy to state and capable of generating solutions to a broad range of moral dilemmas. This simplicity allows utilitarianism to provide **action guidance**: agents can compare the expected consequences of available options and choose the one that maximises well-being. The theory's scope is universal; it applies to individuals, institutions, policies and global systems[22]. Because utilitarianism evaluates moral choices on a common scale of welfare, it encourages **empirical investigation** into what actually promotes or harms well-being, aligning morality with social science and public policy.

The theory also exhibits **explanatory power**. Many of our moral intuitions are consequence-based: we condemn actions that harm people and praise those that help. Utilitarianism articulates this intuitive core and explains why killing or lying is usually wrong (it tends to cause harm), while allowing for exceptions when consequences are extraordinarily good. Compared with deontological theories that rely on lists of duties, utilitarianism provides a unified explanation of moral rightness.

2.2 Impartiality, equality and the veil of ignorance

Because utilitarianism demands **equal consideration** of all persons' interests, it captures a deep intuition about fairness. In his pioneering work on social choice, economist John Harsanyi argued that rational agents behind a **veil of ignorance** (not knowing their position in society) would choose principles that maximise the **sum total of well-being**[23]. The veil removes personal bias and appeals to impartiality: since any individual might end up in any social position, everyone has reason to adopt a principle that maximises overall welfare. Harsanyi's theorem thus shows that utilitarian aggregation follows from rational choice under risk, provided agents are impartial and risk-neutral. Even critics of utilitarianism like John Rawls acknowledge that a concern for the worse-off is motivated by similar veil-of-ignorance reasoning.

2.3 Reflective equilibrium and moral circle expansion

Utilitarian philosophers advocate **reflective equilibrium**: balancing specific moral intuitions with general theoretical principles. Our intuitions are often biased by cultural upbringing, status quo bias or the identifiable victim effect[9]. By adopting an impartial stance and considering all affected parties, utilitarianism corrects for these biases and leads to surprising but arguably justified conclusions. For example, many people believe it is more important to save a neighbour than a stranger overseas. But the equal moral worth of all persons implies that if one can save several strangers at little cost, one ought to do so. Utilitarianism has supported **moral circle expansion**, urging us to include non-human animals, future generations and distant strangers within our moral concern[9].

2.4 Action guidance and policy success

Utilitarianism underlies many practical decision-making tools. **Cost–benefit analysis** and **cost-effectiveness analysis** in public policy are explicitly utilitarian: they require comparing the expected benefits and harms of policies and choosing those that maximise overall welfare. In global health, cost-effectiveness analysis helps allocate scarce resources to interventions that save the most lives per dollar; ignoring efficiency can result in more deaths[24]. Utilitarian principles have motivated public health measures such as vaccination campaigns, road safety laws and pandemic lockdowns by emphasising aggregate consequences. In **effective altruism**, individuals attempt to identify the most pressing problems—global poverty, farm animal welfare, existential risks—and direct their resources towards interventions that provide the greatest benefit[25]. The movement emphasises cause prioritisation, careful research and impartiality[25]. Utilitarianism thus provides a framework for **cause impartial** decision making, encouraging individuals to consider where their resources can produce the most good.

2.5 Poverty of alternatives and comparative advantages

Critics of deontological ethics have pointed out the **paradox of deontology**: strict adherence to duties (e.g., never lie, never kill) can lead to disastrous outcomes, such as letting many people die to avoid killing one. Utilitarianism avoids this paradox by allowing rights to be overridden when consequences are sufficiently weighty. Moreover, utilitarianism arguably offers a more plausible explanation of **moral progress** than its rivals. Historically, appeals to welfare and impartiality have

supported the abolition of slavery, women's suffrage, recognition of LGBTQ+ rights and improved animal welfare. Utilitarian arguments emphasise that suffering and happiness are what ultimately matter, and that we should not privilege certain groups based on arbitrary traits[9]. Even if utilitarianism faces challenges, many philosophers claim that alternative theories often fare no better or worse; for instance, deontological theories struggle to justify moral duties without appealing to consequences, and virtue ethics lacks clear action guidance.

3 Objections to Utilitarianism

Despite its appeal, utilitarianism faces numerous objections. Philosophers have raised concerns about rights, demandingness, measurement, distributive justice, moral integrity and more. This section reviews major critiques, illustrating them with thought experiments and real-world cases.

3.1 Rights, justice and the tyranny of the majority

One of the most persistent objections is that utilitarianism can **violate individual rights** when doing so maximises aggregate welfare. The **transplant** (or **surgeon**) thought experiment imagines a doctor who kills a healthy patient to harvest organs for five dying patients. On a naïve utilitarian calculation, sacrificing one to save five maximises welfare, yet most people judge such an act morally abhorrent[26]. Similarly, imagine a town terrified by a murder; the police, lacking leads, frame an innocent man to restore public calm. The scapegoat's suffering is outweighed by the community's relief, but falsely imprisoning him seems unjust[26]. These **tyranny-of-the-majority** scenarios show how aggregating welfare can lead to exploitation of individuals or minorities.

Utilitarians respond that such violations rarely maximise welfare when one considers **long-term consequences**. A practice of harvesting organs would undermine trust in doctors and deter people from seeking medical care, causing greater harm[27]. Similarly, framing the innocent would erode confidence in law enforcement. This response, however, turns on empirical claims; if killing one truly did produce more overall welfare, act utilitarianism would endorse it. Rule utilitarianism attempts to avoid this by adopting rules prohibiting rights violations. Yet critics argue that rule utilitarianism collapses into act utilitarianism when rules can be revised or when exceptions are permitted.

3.2 Demandingness, impartiality and personal relationships

Utilitarianism requires impartial maximisation of well-being, making **no moral distinction** between oneself, one's loved ones and strangers. Critics argue that this is **too demanding**: it implies that one must continuously sacrifice personal goals and relationships whenever doing so would increase overall welfare. The demandingness objection is illustrated by the everyday decision to dine at a restaurant rather than donating that money to save lives from malaria. On a strict utilitarian view, choosing pleasure over saving lives is wrong[28]. Bernard Williams's thought experiments underscore the conflict between utilitarianism and **personal integrity**. In **George the chemist**, George is offered a job in a chemical weapons laboratory; if he declines, the position will go to a more enthusiastic candidate. Utilitarianism tells George to take the job to minimise harm, yet many believe that doing so would compromise his moral integrity[29]. In **Jim and the Indians**, Jim encounters a firing squad about to execute twenty villagers; he is offered the chance to shoot one of them to save the other nineteen. Williams argues that utilitarianism's recommendation—that Jim kill one to save many—ignores Jim's relationship to his own actions and responsibility[30].

Utilitarian impartiality also seems to undervalue **special obligations** to family and friends. Ordinary moral thought holds that parents may justifiably give more time and resources to their children than to strangers; utilitarianism struggles to justify such partiality. Some utilitarians reply that promoting stable family bonds ultimately maximises welfare, while others accept that utilitarianism is an ideal theory that we can rarely achieve.

3.3 Measurement, comparability and epistemic problems

Another major challenge concerns the **measurement of well-being**. Critics argue that **human happiness is impossible to quantify**: experiences are subjective and vary widely, making interpersonal comparisons unreliable[31]. Utilitarianism presupposes that we can add up diverse pleasures and pains on a single scale, yet there is no agreed metric for doing so. Moreover, utilitarian calculations must anticipate future consequences, but these are often uncertain or unknowable. The **cluelessness** objection emphasises that small changes can have unpredictable long-term effects; saving a drowning child today may alter the course of history in unforeseeable ways[32]. If we cannot know the true outcomes of our actions, utilitarianism seems to be an unusable guide.

The theory also ignores **motives**. If two people donate to charity, one from genuine concern and the other for selfish public image, utilitarianism values the larger donation more, even if the motive is ignoble[33]. Many believe that motives are morally relevant. Although rule or virtue utilitarians may incorporate motives into their assessment of acts or agents, act utilitarianism remains insensitive to intent.

3.4 Distributive fairness and population ethics

Utilitarianism evaluates outcomes by their total or average well-being, which can yield counterintuitive implications for **distribution**. Robert Nozick's **utility monster** argument imagines a being who experiences vastly more pleasure from resources than others; utilitarianism would require sacrificing everyone's well-being to satisfy the monster[18]. The **repugnant conclusion** shows that, under the total view, a world containing a vast number of people whose lives are barely worth living can be better than a smaller world with fewer extremely happy people[19]. The **average view**, which compares average welfare across populations, avoids the repugnant conclusion but leads to the **sadistic conclusion**: adding extremely unhappy people can increase average welfare if existing lives are sufficiently miserable[20]. **Variable value** and **critical-level** theories attempt to avoid these paradoxes by discounting additional lives beyond a certain quality threshold[21]. Critics argue that no utilitarian population principle can avoid all counterintuitive implications.

Distributive objections also arise in everyday contexts. Utilitarianism can justify extreme wealth disparities if allocating resources to the wealthy produces more total welfare, for example, by enabling innovation. Critics worry that utilitarianism neglects **equality** and **justice**. The theory treats interpersonal welfare differences as commensurable, but some hold that fairness requires prioritising the worst-off regardless of aggregate benefits. Prioritarian and egalitarian modifications attempt to address this by weighing benefits to the disadvantaged more heavily.

3.5 Authenticity, experience and plural values

Robert Nozick's **experience machine** thought experiment questions hedonistic utilitarianism. Would you plug into a machine that gives you any experiences you desire? Many people refuse; they value *actually* doing things, being a certain kind of person and living in touch with reality[34]. This suggests that pleasure alone is not the sole intrinsic good. **Pluralists** argue that autonomy, knowledge, friendship and virtue are independent values that utilitarianism cannot reduce to hedonic

or preference satisfaction. The theory may also lack room for **desert**: we generally believe that people deserve outcomes proportional to their effort and virtue, not simply those that maximise aggregate welfare.

4 Responses and refinements

Utilitarians have developed a variety of refinements to meet these objections. The diversity of these responses illustrates utilitarianism's flexibility but also its vulnerability to complexity.

4.1 Rule utilitarianism and multi-level decision procedures

Rule utilitarianism proposes evaluating moral rules rather than individual acts. If a rule requiring doctors to respect patients' rights maximises welfare, we should adopt it even when violating the rule seems locally beneficial. This, it is claimed, protects rights and avoids tyranny-of-the-majority cases. Critics respond that if following a rule in a particular case reduces welfare, act utilitarianism would endorse making an exception; thus, rule utilitarianism risks collapsing back into act utilitarianism.

Multi-level utilitarianism and Hare's **two-level theory** offer a more pragmatic response[17]. On these views, utilitarianism remains the ultimate criterion but is not used as a direct decision procedure. Instead, agents should internalise simple moral rules (e.g., "do not lie," "keep promises," "do not harm others") and develop virtuous dispositions. These heuristics are justified by their general tendency to maximise welfare. One reverts to critical utilitarian reasoning only in unusual cases where the heuristic clearly misfires. This acknowledges human cognitive limitations and addresses the demandingness objection by allowing ordinary moral thinking to be guided by intuitive rules[7].

4.2 Negative utilitarianism, prioritarianism and distribution-sensitive forms

To address concerns about extreme suffering, some utilitarians advocate **negative utilitarianism**, which prioritises the reduction of suffering over the promotion of happiness[11]. Moderate negative utilitarianism gives extra weight to preventing severe pain while still valuing positive experiences.

Prioritarianism modifies the aggregation function by weighting benefits to the worse-off more heavily, thereby addressing inequality and avoiding the utility monster. **Lexical utilitarianism** (or **leximin utilitarianism**) ranks outcomes lexically: first maximise the welfare of the worst-off, then

the next worst, and so on. These distribution-sensitive utilitarianisms aim to reconcile aggregate welfare with egalitarian intuitions.

4.3 Preference, ideal and objective list utilitarianism

Hedonistic utilitarianism is vulnerable to the experience machine objection. **Preference utilitarianism**, therefore, identifies welfare with the satisfaction of informed preferences[11]. **Ideal** or **objective list utilitarianism** includes goods such as knowledge, accomplishment and deep personal relationships in the utility function[12]. These theories better accommodate diverse human values but face the difficulty of comparing heterogeneous goods and dealing with adaptive or distorted preferences. Some propose **capabilities utilitarianism**, which evaluates well-being in terms of capabilities to function in various ways (borrowing from Amartya Sen and Martha Nussbaum). Others advocate **virtue utilitarianism**, which assesses character traits and motives by their contribution to well-being[22].

4.4 Expectational utilitarianism, risk and moral uncertainty

Given epistemic limits, **expectational utilitarianism** instructs agents to choose actions with the highest expected utility[15]. This formalises decision-making under uncertainty using probabilities. To address long-term cluelessness, some propose **risk-averse utilitarianism** or **weighted expectations**, giving less weight to highly uncertain outcomes. Others supplement utilitarian calculation with **precautionary principles** or **ethical hedging** when the moral consequences of errors are severe. **Moral uncertainty** theories suggest combining utilitarianism with other ethical theories using decision-theoretic tools, so that one hedges against the risk that utilitarianism might be wrong.

4.5 Hybrid and threshold theories

Many philosophers adopt **hybrid theories** that integrate utilitarian aggregation with deontological side constraints or virtue ethics. **Threshold deontology** holds that rights and duties are normally inviolable but may be overridden when the consequences are sufficiently catastrophic. **Side-constraint utilitarianism** attaches independent weight to rights but uses utilitarianism to adjudicate conflicts among rights or to resolve cases beyond the threshold. Others advocate **pluralistic consequentialism**, which recognises multiple intrinsic values (e.g., justice, friendship,

beauty) alongside well-being. These hybrids aim to preserve utilitarianism's strengths—its impartiality and outcome focus—while accommodating non-consequentialist insights.

4.6 Debunking intuitions and moral education

Some utilitarians respond to rights and integrity objections by **debunking** anti-utilitarian intuitions. Experimental psychology shows that people's moral judgements are influenced by factors such as **identifiable victims**, **proximity**, group loyalty and status-quo bias[9]. Such biases may explain why we feel reluctant to harm one to save many. Proponents, therefore, argue that intuitive resistance to utilitarianism is not a reliable guide to moral truth. They advocate **moral education** aimed at expanding empathy and overcoming parochial biases. Others “bite the bullet,” accepting that our ordinary intuitions may be mistaken and that true morality may require significant sacrifice[28]. Multi-level utilitarianism offers a compromise: follow simple moral rules in daily life but be prepared to make difficult sacrifices when the stakes are very high[17].

5 Evaluation and conclusion

Utilitarianism is one of the most influential ethical theories and continues to shape moral philosophy, economics, politics and law. Its strengths and weaknesses reflect deeper tensions between impartiality and personal attachment, outcome focus and rights, and simplicity and complexity.

Strengths:

- **Impartial concern for all.** Utilitarianism's demand that each person's (and animal's) welfare counts equally combats parochialism and motivates moral progress[9]. It provides a compelling basis for expanding the moral circle to include animals, future generations and distant strangers.
- **Outcome orientation and action guidance.** By focusing on consequences, utilitarianism captures our intuitive praise of beneficial acts and condemnation of harmful ones. It supplies a systematic method for evaluating policies and informs cost–benefit analyses in health, environmental and social policy[24]. Practical movements like effective altruism translate utilitarian ideals into concrete recommendations about where to donate and what careers to pursue[25].

- **Simplicity and universality.** A single maxim—maximise well-being—offers a unified moral framework. Utilitarianism applies across contexts: from personal decisions to corporate policies, public law and global governance[22]. It encourages empirical research into human and animal welfare and adapts to new circumstances (e.g., artificial intelligence or climate ethics).
- **Flexibility and reformulation.** The proliferation of variants—rule, multi-level, negative, prioritarian, scalar, expectational and hybrid—shows that utilitarianism can be refined to address specific concerns while retaining its core commitment to promoting well-being.

Weaknesses:

- **Conflict with rights and justice.** Utilitarianism appears willing to sacrifice individuals for the greater good, as illustrated by the transplant and scapegoat cases[26]. Protecting rights may require adding non-consequentialist constraints or adopting hybrid theories.
- **Demandingness and integrity.** The requirement to prioritise strangers' welfare over personal projects and relationships can seem excessively demanding[28]. Williams's cases highlight the loss of personal integrity when utilitarianism compels us to act against our character[29].
- **Measurement and epistemic uncertainty.** Happiness is hard to measure, interpersonal comparisons are contentious and long-term consequences are unpredictable[31][32]. These epistemic limits challenge utilitarian decision-making.
- **Distributive fairness and population ethics.** Aggregative welfare can endorse extreme inequality or require adding barely worthwhile lives[19]. Modified theories attempt to address this but often introduce further complexity and still face paradoxes.
- **Plural values and authenticity.** The experience machine suggests that pleasure alone does not capture all that matters[34]. Preference and ideal utilitarianism incorporate other values but raise questions about comparability and adaptive preferences.

Conclusion:

Utilitarianism provides a powerful framework for moral reasoning and has significantly influenced public policy and social reform. Its core idea—that we should strive to make the world as good as possible for everyone—remains attractive. Yet the theory's demandingness and counterintuitive

implications warrant caution and refinement. Philosophers have responded with a spectrum of modifications—from rule utilitarianism and multi-level heuristics to prioritarian, negative and hybrid theories. Whether utilitarianism can accommodate all moral intuitions without losing its identity is an open question. What is clear is that any plausible moral theory must grapple with the tension between individual rights, equality, outcomes and plural values. For students of philosophy, utilitarianism offers both a compelling ethical vision and a fertile ground for exploring the complexities of moral reasoning.

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